

Heart of Corundum

Story draft by Audrey

There once was a robot girl named LFTR-03-251 who worked in a spaceship manufacturing yard orbiting Encedalus, a cold and barren moon of Saturn. Her entire existence had been spent doing the same kind of labor for decades, sent off to various different manufacturing plants and construction sites, until she ended up here. It was a lonely outpost with no civilization to speak of, but she had a friendly community of fellow workers there, and the work was gratifying. The only trouble was that her old body was breaking down, and replacement parts were hard to come by for an obsolete model like hers, so she had to use her own skills to improvise repairs. Through her own resourcefulness, she managed to keep herself and her crew mates in working order when the company responsible for them failed to provide proper maintenance. She had the reputation of a clever inventor among her peers.

One day, word spread around the shipyard that Eris Promethia, the founder of Daedalus Robotics, creator of the robot workforce and a legendary figure among the solar system, was coming to their worksite for unknown reasons. This had all the workers abuzz with excitement-- what could a celebrity like her be doing at a remote backwater like theirs? None were more excited than LFTR-03-251, who idolized Ms. Promethia as a fellow inventor.

When Eris arrived on the worksite, she singled out LFTR-03-251 and asked her for a private meeting. She identified LFTR-03-251 as the oldest functioning robot created by Daedalus, and wanted to bring her to Saturn for the public launch of a new line of bio-mechanical robot chassis. As a show of goodwill to aging models in Daedalus's workforce, Eris planned to upload the minds of older workers into the new chassis, giving them a fresh start and freeing them from the immediate danger of breaking down or being decommissioned. Starstruck and amazed by Eris's generosity, LFTR agreed to be the public face of this PR campaign.

Eris and LFTR set off for Saturn, to a great domed city floating above the clouds, where the headquarters for Daedalus Robotics were situated. It was LFTR's first time planet-side, and her first time in such a busy place, surrounded by so many people. She was awed by the sights and sounds.

They arrived at Daedalus Robotics headquarters, a luxurious facility home to Eris's research laboratory and living quarters. In Eris's bedroom, a prototype of LFTR's new bio-mechanical body was proudly on display in a glass case. It was fully operational, except for one crucial component: an artificial heart. On the day of the public unveiling ceremony, LFTR's mind would be transferred to the chassis, and the artificial heart installed, bringing the body to life as a symbolic gesture.

The two of them would get plenty of quality time together until the ceremony. Eris was eager to open up LFTR in the laboratory and examine her inner workings, in order to prepare her for transfer. LFTR was overjoyed to spend personal time with a figure she idolized, and excited about the intimacy of the experiments. The two grew close. They even shared Eris's bedroom, where they continued some of their intimate activities after dark.

During a maintenance session one day, Eris discussed some news that troubled her. A worker rebellion had just occurred on Mars. Company officials blamed this incident on a flaw in the design of LFTR robots, and promptly decommissioned all LFTR units on the planet. Because of this supposed flaw, all LFTR units across the solar system were under suspicion, meaning they would not be eligible to receive new chassis.

Eris assured LFTR that she was in no danger of being decommissioned, however, and she would still receive the new body she was promised. The PR campaign would go forward as planned, and the general public would be assured that Daedalus's old workforce would receive the upgrade. However, the old units would be quietly left to continue their work under close supervision until end of life, and the new chassis would be given fresh minds. The company could not afford to let the seed of rebellion pass on to a new generation of robots.

This soured LFTR's mood. At first, she sympathized with Eris, believing that companies needed to make hard decisions sometimes. However, she grew more resentful over time. She grew weary of Eris's experiments on her body, suddenly finding them invasive and uncomfortable. They began to argue. LFTR would speak of the unfairness of the decision, and Eris would double down, describing both LFTR and the rest of the robot workforce as her property to do what she pleased with. The experiments continued, and despite LFTR's obvious discomfort, Eris continued taking great pleasure in her work.

On the day before the ceremony, LFTR was accosted and detained by Daedalus security forces. This outraged her. Eris took LFTR to the bedroom for a private discussion to break the bad news to her. Due to her behavior over the preceding days, the company considered LFTR too much of a risk to represent the company for this ceremony. She would be shipped back to her workplace on Encedalus, and another candidate would be chosen for the symbolic transfer. Eris acted upset and apologetic about the decision, wishing that LFTR could have received the special treatment she so deserved.

LFTR was unconvinced of Eris's sincerity, and resentful of the way the woman regarded her kin. She was more angry than she had ever been. In a fit of rage, LFTR thrust her rusty metal hand straight through Eris's chest and pulled out her still-beating heart. Eris installed the heart into the new body's chest, and performed the mind transfer right then and there. She took her stolen body and fled the scene.